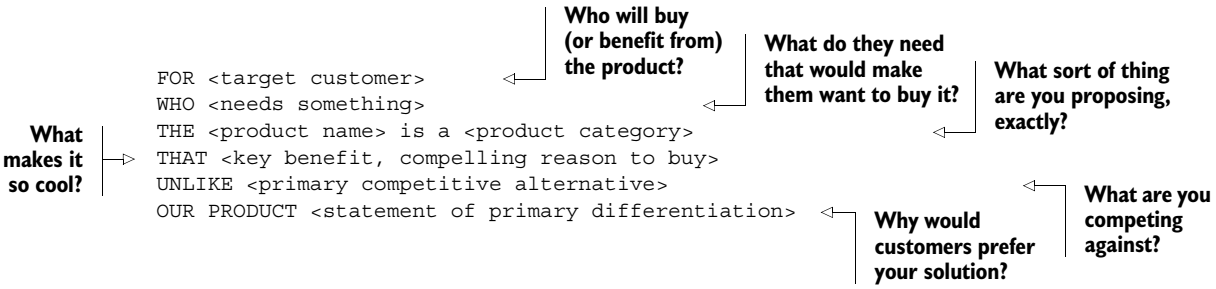
A good vision statement will focus on the project's objectives, and not on how it will deliver these objectives. It won't go into details about what technology should be used, what timeframe the project delivery should respect, or what platform it should run on. Rather, it presents the project objectives in the context of the problem the project is trying to address.

Most traditional projects generally do have a vision of some sort. Executive managers usually know, at least in the back of their minds, what they expect out of a project in terms of business value, or they wouldn't have approved it. By the nature of their jobs, executives usually have a very keen understanding of how a project is expected to contribute to the bottom line. Despite this, they may not have articulated the expected outcomes in a way that can be easily shared with the development team.

Larger organizations typically require some sort of formal documentation that explains the business case and scope of a project, and this document will usually contain a vision statement of sorts. But these are often dry, rigid documents, written to respect the local project management process requirements, and they're relegated to a project management office once the project has been signed-off on. They're the realm of project managers and project management offices (PMOs). In many cases, these documents never make it to the development team, which effectively renders them useless as vision statements in the Agile sense. Indeed, how can a shared vision be useful if not everyone can see it?

3.3.2 Using vision statement templates

A project vision statement need not be a long and wordy document. It can be a succinct paragraph that sums up the focus of the project in one or two sentences. In his book *Crossing the Chasm: Marketing and Selling High-Tech Products to Mainstream Customers* (Harper Business, 2002), Geoffrey A. Moore proposes the following template for a good product vision statement, which I've often heard mentioned in Agile circles:




```
FOR <target customer>
WHO <needs something>
THE <product name> is a <product category>
THAT <key benefit, compelling reason to buy>
UNLIKE <primary competitive alternative>
OUR PRODUCT <statement of primary differentiation>
```

For example, the vision statement for Flying High's Frequent Flyer program might go something like this:

```
FOR travellers
WHO want to be rewarded for travelling with Flying High Airlines
THE Flying High Frequent Flyer program IS A loyalty program
THAT lets members easily and conveniently view and manage their accumulated
     points in real time, and spend their points for real purchases with
     unequaled ease.
```